Cranberry Walnut Bread

by Henry Hunter • recipepantry.app



PREP TIME	FERMENTATION	BAKE TIME	YIELD
30 minutes	**20-26 hours**	**40-45 minutes**	**1 loaf (about 1,100g), 12 slices**

Tart cranberries pop against toasted walnuts with a crust that shatters when you slice it.

Ingredients

Levain (build night before)

50g	Active sourdough starter
100g	Water (80-85°F / 27-29°C)
100g	Bread flour

Dough

~250g	Levain (all of it)
375g	Water (80-85°F / 27-29°C)
500g	Bread flour
10g	Fine sea salt
75g	Dried cranberries
75g	Walnuts, toasted and coarsely chopped

Equipment

- Large mixing bowl
- Kitchen scale
- Bench scraper
- Banneton basket (or a bowl lined with a floured towel)
- Dutch oven with lid (5 to 6 quart)
- Lame or sharp knife
- Parchment paper
- Wire cooling rack

Instructions

1. Build Your Levain

Mix 50g active sourdough starter with 100g water (80-85°F) and 100g bread flour in a clean jar. Stir until combined, cover loosely, and let sit at room temperature overnight. You want it bubbly and doubled by morning, with a domed top.

1. **Combine starter and water**

   Mix 50g active sourdough starter with 100g water (80-85°F) in a clean jar.

   ◯ **50g** Sourdough starter ◯ **100g** Water

2. **Add flour**

   Add 100g bread flour and stir until combined.

3. **Rest overnight**

   Cover loosely and let sit at room temperature overnight (8-10 hours). It should be bubbly and doubled by morning.

2. Prepare Inclusions

Toast walnuts and soak cranberries before mixing your dough.

1. **Toast walnuts**

   Spread walnuts on a baking sheet and toast at 350°F for 5-7 minutes until fragrant. Let cool completely, then chop coarsely.

2. **Soak cranberries**

   Soak dried cranberries in warm water for 15 minutes to plump them. Drain well and pat completely dry with a towel.

3. Mix the Dough

Combine your levain with water and flour for the autolyse.

1. **Dissolve levain**

   In a large bowl, add 375g water (80-85°F) and dissolve all of your levain into it.

   ◯ **~250g** Levain ◯ **375g** Water

2. **Add flour**

   Add 500g bread flour and mix with your hands until no dry flour remains. The dough will look shaggy and rough.

3. **Autolyse**

   Cover and let rest for 45 minutes. This autolyse develops gluten without effort.

4. Add Salt and Develop Strength

Incorporate salt and begin building gluten structure.

1. **Add salt**

   Sprinkle 10g salt over the dough.

2. **Incorporate**

   Pinch and fold the dough repeatedly for about 5 minutes until the salt is fully incorporated and the dough starts to tighten up.

3. **Rest**

   Cover and rest for 30 minutes.

5. Stretch and Folds with Inclusions

Build strength and incorporate the cranberries and walnuts.

1. **First set of folds**

   Wet your hand, grab one side of the dough, stretch it up, and fold it over itself. Rotate the bowl a quarter turn and repeat 4 times total. Rest 30 minutes.

2. **Test dough strength**

   Try pressing in a small handful of cranberries and walnuts. If the dough tears or goes slack, do another set of folds, wait 30 minutes, then try again.

3. **Add half the inclusions**

   If the dough holds together, add half your cranberries and walnuts and fold them in gently. Rest 30 minutes.

4. **Second set of folds**

   Add the remaining cranberries and walnuts and do another round of stretch and folds. Rest 30 minutes.

5. **Third set of folds**

   Final stretch and folds. The dough should feel smooth, strong, and slightly puffy.

6. Bulk Fermentation

Let the dough ferment at room temperature for about 4 to 5 hours total from mixing. Go by the dough, not the clock: volume up about 50%, a domed top, bubbles visible under the surface, and a finger indent that slowly springs back halfway.

1. **Monitor fermentation**

   Cover and let ferment. Watch for 50% volume increase, visible bubbles, and dome formation.

2. **Check readiness**

   Press a finger in. The indent should slowly spring back halfway. Trust what you see over the clock.

Shape Your Loaf

Boule (Round)

1. **Pre-shape**

   Turn dough out onto a lightly floured surface. Preshape into a round by pulling edges toward the center, creating tension on the surface.

2. **Bench rest**

   Let rest 15-20 minutes uncovered (bench rest).

3. **Final shape**

   Flip the dough so smooth side is down. Fold edges to center again, creating a tight ball. Flip over and drag across counter to build surface tension.

4. **Into banneton**

   Place seam-side up in a well-floured banneton or bowl lined with floured towel.

Bake Your Loaf

Temperature: 450°F / 230°C

IF USING: DUTCH OVEN

1. Preheat

About 45 minutes before baking, place the Dutch oven with its lid in the oven and heat to 450°F (230°C). Leave the loaf in the fridge until you're ready to load it.

2. Prepare loaf

Turn the cold loaf out onto parchment paper. Score the top with a lame or sharp knife. One deep slash down the center works great.

3. Load Dutch oven

Carefully remove the hot Dutch oven, lower in the loaf (parchment and all), and cover with the lid.

4. Steam bake

Bake covered at 450°F (230°C) for 20 minutes for oven spring.

5. Finish bake

Remove the lid, lower the oven to 425°F (220°C), and bake 20-25 minutes until deep golden brown and the internal temperature reaches 205-210°F (96-99°C). The lower heat keeps the cranberries and walnuts from scorching.

6. Cool

Transfer to a wire rack and cool for at least 1 hour before slicing. The crumb is still setting.

Storage

Room Temperature: Store wrapped in a towel or in a bread bag for up to 3 days. The cranberries and walnuts keep it moist.

Refrigerated: Not recommended. Refrigeration accelerates staling.

Frozen: Slice and freeze for up to 2 months. Toast frozen slices for breakfast or cheese plates.

Refresh: Warm slices in a 300°F oven for 5 minutes to refresh.

FAQ

Can I use fresh cranberries instead of dried?

Dried works better. Fresh cranberries add too much moisture and can make your dough too wet to handle. If you must use fresh, pat them completely dry and reduce the amount to 50g maximum.

Do I have to use a Dutch oven?

A Dutch oven gives the best oven spring and crust, but you can bake on a stone with steam. Just know your results will vary.

Why is my dough tearing when I add the inclusions?

You added them before the gluten was strong enough. Do more stretch and folds to build strength first, then try again. The dough should feel elastic and hold together before you add heavy mix-ins.

How do I know when bulk fermentation is done?

Look for about a 50% volume increase, visible bubbles under the surface, a domed top, and a dough that springs back slowly when poked.

My loaf didn't rise much in the oven. What happened?

Most often the dough was underproofed in bulk or overproofed in the fridge, or the starter wasn't active enough. Check your starter first. It should double within 6 to 8 hours of feeding.

Can I skip the cold proof?

Yes. After shaping, proof at room temperature for 1 to 2 hours until a floured finger indent springs back slowly, then bake the same way. The loaf will taste milder and be harder to score cleanly.

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